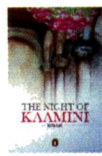


SAURABH SINGH



Period Plodder

Purple prose and colourful history combine in a soppy soap opera



THE NIGHT OF KAAMINI

by BELA LAL

Penguin

Price: Rs 299

Pages: 374

■ By Geeta Doctor

It must be an indication of the unheroic times we live in that fiction writers are now going back to grandpa's days of glory. "What did you do, Grandpa, during Independence struggle?" they seem to be asking. The freedom movement is emerging as the second World War event in our literary memory. It's seen as the one defining moment in history when ordinary people were forced to make choices that are being felt by the children of today. At least this is how Bela Lal puts it, when she sets the scene for her triple generational saga, *The Night of Kaamini*. "The dawn was full of colours—purple and cerise, but it was streaked with gray. There was a trail of blood, the smell was rotten, it fouled the air."

After the strum und drang of her opening paragraphs, Lal does settle down to tell her story in neatly interwoven parallels of "Before" and "After". Her narrator is a well-educated modern young woman called Mita, who tootles off to the wilds of her maternal grandfather's home to investigate her past, since she is now involved with a young man named Amit. His parents carry on like a soap opera staples who rear up when

the word "shaadi" is mentioned, so some things never change apparently.

Lal has got a huge mass of material to plough through and like a Merchant-Ivory film, where the gorgeousness of old crumbling palaces overwhelms the scenes in which the actors loll around, she never knows when to stop her characters from gorging themselves in the sensuality of the moment. At the same time, she is also a historian. She brings the history of the Independence period alive through her characters. This is not just a love story of Mita's beautiful grandmother and the mystery about her parentage to be prized out of her own mother, Kaamini, but a serious historical novel. It's as if Rebecca West had decided that she wanted to write like Barbara Cartland, perhaps not such a far-fetched idea since Dame West was for some years so besotted with being a mistress to H.G. Wells that she compared his body to the smell of honey.

That, of course, is the difference. A trace of honey is more than adequate. But Lal tends to give you lashings of the stuff. The historical bits are interesting. They, however, belong to another kind of book. There's also a spelling error in the name of Potti Sriramulu, a Telugu leader whose fast unto death led to the formation of linguistic states. He's named Patti which means grandma in Tamil. Since the novel is also about Mita's grandma, it could be said that both Pattis did their best to stir things up.

Shadow Lines

Abrar Alvi is finally centrestage, and in his own words



TEN YEARS WITH GURU DUTT: ABRAR

ALVI'S JOURNEY

by SATHYA SARAN

Penguin/Viking

Price: Rs 499; Pages: 216

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

You would think after so many books and retrospectives on Guru Dutt, no one would want to read or write another word on the maestro. You couldn't be more wrong. The past month saw a well-researched booklet on the filmmaker by Rashmi Doraiswamy as part of *The Legends of Indian Cinema* series, and now Sathya Saran has given a patient hearing to his one-time collaborator Abrar Alvi, who many believe was just a front for Dutt's direction of *Sahib Bibi Aur Ghulam*.

As Saran tells it, echoing Alvi's words, everyone was wrong. *Ghulam*, a masterpiece that stands out for the sensuality of Meena Kumari and the rustic innocence of Dutt, was conceived entirely by Alvi, except for the song picturisations. Clearly, this is an argument that is not likely to end anytime soon and Dutt is no longer alive to set the record straight but this book is not interesting for that reason. As a treatise on the making of *Sahib Bibi Aur Ghulam*, it makes absorbing reading. From how the last scene had to be shot without Waheeda Rehman and Dutt touching each other (they had broken up by that time) to how Meena Kumari was shot (either in profile or three-fourths angle from the other side to prevent her face from looking too broad), it makes the film come alive beyond its haunting frames. And from Meena Kumari smashing her fist into the wall for not getting her intonation right to her fear of getting beaten up by both her husband Kamal Amrohi and his right-hand man, Baker, it puts the spotlight on one of Indian cinema's greatest women actors. Now that's a big book waiting to be written. Will Gulzar, who knew her best, oblige?